Panel from a Window Frame

From the mausoleum of Sayyida Nafisa

Fatimid, 531-32 or 540-41 AH / 1137-38 or 1146-47 CE

Wood

W: 129 cm; H: 43 cm

Inv. no. 1648



This finely interlocked and carved wooden panel once formed the upper section of a window frame from the mausoleum of Sayyida Nafisa. A complete example from the same site, housed in the Museum's permanent collection (Inv. No. 1645), suggests the two once formed a matching set. The work is generally dated to 1137-38 or 1146-47 (521-32 or 540-41 AH), corresponding to the restoration campaigns undertaken at the shrine by the Fatimid caliph al-Hafiz. Together with its intact counterpart

and the celebrated portable wooden mihrab from the mausoleum (Inv. No. 421), this fragment stands as a testament to the exquisite craftsmanship of this era, showcasing the intricate interplay of geometric frameworks and luxuriant vegetal ornament, likely once complemented, as in Inv. No. 1645, by carved inscriptions.

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